

AP Computer Science Principles – Course Syllabus 2026–27

Teacher: [Your name] • Room: [] • Email: [] • Office hours / help time: []

Course description

AP Computer Science Principles (AP CSP) introduces the big ideas of computing: how programs are designed and built, how data is represented and used, how algorithms and programming solve problems, how the Internet works, and how computing affects people and society. We program in **Python** and also learn the **AP pseudocode** used on the exam. No prior experience is required.

The five Big Ideas

Unit	Big Idea	Approx. dates
1	Creative Development	September – mid-October
2	Data	mid-October – early November
3	Algorithms & Programming	November – early February
—	Create Performance Task	mid-February – mid-March
4	Computer Systems & Networks	March
5	Impact of Computing	April
—	AP exam review	late April – May

The AP exam

- **Create Performance Task (about 30%):** students build their own program, submit the code, a short video, and a Personalized Project Reference by the College Board deadline (typically April 30), then answer written-response questions about it on exam day. Students receive at least 9 hours of class time to work on it.
- **Multiple-choice exam (about 70%):** 70 questions in 120 minutes in May. Exam date: [check College Board calendar].
- Students who take the AP exam may earn college credit or placement, depending on the college.

Materials

- A **composition notebook** (for notes and the Create Task notebook pages)
- Pencil and a highlighter
- A charged laptop/Chromebook [or school device] with access to a Python editor: []

Grading

Category	Weight
Tests (unit tests, midterm, practice exam)	[35]%
Quizzes	[15]%
Labs (Python)	[20]%
Classwork, worksheets & homework	[15]%
Create Task process (notebook, checkpoints)	[15]%

Grading scale: [A 90–100, B 80–89, C 70–79, D 60–69, F below 60]

Class policies

- **Late work:** []
- **Retakes / test corrections:** []
- **Academic integrity:** Your work must be your own. You may use outside code, tutorials, or AI tools only when allowed, and you must give credit for any code you didn't write. On the Create Task, you must be able to explain every line of your program.
- **Collaboration:** Pair programming is part of this class. Partners switch roles and both must understand the code.
- **Devices:** []

What a typical week looks like

- **Monday & Tuesday (55 min):** guided notes, practice, worksheets, quizzes
- **Thursday (80 min):** Python coding labs, quizzes, and tests

Letter to Families

Dear families,

Welcome to AP Computer Science Principles! This year your student will learn how computers and the Internet work, how to write programs in Python, and how technology affects our lives and communities. They'll complete a major independent project, the **Create Performance Task**, in February and March, and take the AP exam in May.

How you can help: - Ask your student to show you a program they wrote in a lab. - Help them protect time in March for the Create Task, and check that it's submitted as final by the deadline. - Encourage them to come for help early — programming gets much easier with practice.

Please contact me anytime at [email].

Sincerely, [Your name]

Please sign and return. We have read the AP CSP syllabus.

Student name: _____ Student signature: _____

Family member name: _____ Signature: _____

Best way to contact you: _____